he is managing the land. There is so much to see, so much to interpret; fifteen years ago, I wouldn't have had the slightest interest.

The farming community is extraordinary. It has its traditions, but it doesn't stand on ceremony. When I was growing up in Essex, our house received a thorough cleaning whenever a visitor was expected. Here, people just knock on the unlocked door unannounced and wander into my in-laws' farmhouse kitchen, where they will always be greeted with a cup of tea.

I would love to become a full-time farmer, but I also want to stay involved in cricket. I'm lucky that my options include commentary, corporate leadership work and even coaching, though to do that well in a team role requires an inordinate amount of time to be spent away from home and family. Since the countryside is such a draw, and I want to see my children grow up, I'm not sure how practical that would be.

I've been told that the key to a successful retirement is to focus on things you enjoy, and I've yet to work out what those will be. A part-time consultancy role in cricket might appeal. Performance sport and successful farming are hard, time-consuming occupations. Could I erect electric fences for sixty days straight? No, I couldn't. Could I do thirty days straight? Probably. Could I do thirty out of sixty? That might be the perfect compromise.

As I have spent more time in the local farming community, I have formed genuine friendships. I am a proud member of the Bastards, the Bedford Agricultural Study, Travel and Rural Development Society.

They made me chairman of the society's cricket club and put me in charge of organizing the Christmas dinner when I was sacked as England's one-day captain, because they reasoned that I had more time on my hands. There is also the Bedfordshire Farmers cricket team, which Tom Turner, a great friend from school and a neighbouring farmer in Great Brickhill, set up. We net on a Tuesday night in Tom's grain shed during the winter and play about fifteen fixtures a season. There is the obvious mid-season break for harvest, and most of the players 'seem' to be sponsored by Gray-Nicolls as my old kit gets a new home! My first game after my last Test match at the Oval was for the Farmers, and unbelievably I got my first ever hat-trick!

When you are done, you're done, aren't you? When I retire from the professional game, I think I'll only retrieve the bats from the attic to play for the Bedfordshire Farmers with my mates. Playing competitive club cricket won't interest me, though I hope to maintain close links with three